MICHELLE HOLZAPFEL
A Mind's Journey in Wood

BY TERRY MARTIN PHOTOS BY DAVID HOLZAPFEL

Of all the artists working in wood I have met, Michelle Holzapfel is the most thoughtful. I had met Michelle several times and always thought there was a confident repose about her which left me wanting to know more. We finally managed to find time when I travelled by train to her home in Vermont. It was a wonderful day-long summer journey which passed from the hustle of downtown Philadelphia, through New York City and into the country. The towns grew smaller, the forest grew closer to the tracks and occasional clearings held single homesteads with dogs that barked at the train as we passed. By the time we arrived in Marlboro I was in a pretty contemplative mood.

I first heard of Michelle in 1982 when a story titled "Woodturning on a Metal Lathe" appeared in *Fine Woodworking*. There were two things that stood out. Firstly, in a field dominated at the time by men, she was a confident woman. Secondly, Michelle broke the rules and used a metal lathe to turn the weed pots and bowls that were her bread-and-butter items. Michelle and her husband David still live in the same house in Marlboro, a small town of around 2,000; Michelle still has the same metal lathe; and she still pays little attention to conventional rules. In the intervening years, her work has crossed so many boundaries that I knew the unfolding of her story would be a real pleasure.

To understand Michelle's art, it is important to know that almost everything she creates is an expression of identity and heritage. We sat in her garden facing the woods and surrounded by flowers while Michelle told me something of her history. She was born in a rural area of Rhode Island, the third of six children, and likes to describe her background: "A lot of my forebears were from Quebec. Many immigrants were attracted to Rhode Island by the mill work. The French Canadians were trappers, or loggers, or farmers, and they came down here to work in the mills in the off-season. We were the cheap migrant workers." Michelle's work reflects the family ethos of careful handwork and make-do common to many poor immigrant families: "My grandfather and father were highly skilled machinists. Most of the female side were needlewomen, as I like to think of them. They were very accomplished. That's where eye/hand coordination was important, making or building things and putting things together. You made what you needed and you fixed what you had. I learned that making things took a lot of thought, time, and care." Michelle not only learned careful needlework from her mother ("I had to be able to sew straight and tidy stitches by hand."), but she also absorbed the skills of her father ("I used to spend a lot of time in the basement workshop with him").

Michelle has strong intellectual interests to match her practical abilities, something that also began at home. "We had a lot of books around and weren't allowed to watch much television. We'd go out into the woods, make perfume from flowers, or build little fern huts. I was good in school, the valedictorian of my class, and I loved math and science. Back then, girls didn't do that, so I wasn't encouraged."

At high school, her art teacher exposed Michelle to a lot of media. She gave Michelle her first set of carving tools, which she still has. "We were doing woodblock prints and I realized immediately that I didn't much care for the prints, but I loved the carving. That's when I became a carver. It was just like my sewing education—a piece of straight pine and hand tools. I got that feeling of cutting through wood with the power of my own body."

In 1969 Michelle heard about Marlboro College, "where the students could call the professors by their first names and wear jeans," so she travelled to Vermont to broaden her horizons. Michelle explained that study was a way for her to break out of what she saw as the restrictions of her background: "This is a serious issue of class—if you are poor, you see this other world out there and you are completely convinced you should be better, whatever 'better' means. After a while I started to ask myself what I was aspiring to. Over the last ten years or so I have come around to really



Michelle Holzapfel carves a bowl nestled in the holding device she made from a piece of tambour.









valuing where I came from and to be more at peace with who I am."

In 1971 Michelle met David. After travelling in Italy for a year, they came back to the United States and started a family. David got a job making burl tables with a man who lived opposite where they live now. This was the fortuitous beginning of two careers in wood, as Michelle explained: "He was quite elderly, and when he died his widow sold us what was left of the business. We had little more than our young bodies and minds, but with help from good friends we got a start. One of the things that we inherited from that business was the contacts with loggers, so they began bringing us all these burls. Our first investment was a chainsaw mill. For many years we milled our own slabs because the commercial sawmills were not interested in all that stuff. It was just the two of us and it was really hard work. David was making the kind of tables the previous owner had made—sand both sides and stick in some legs. We were buying turned legs from somewhere, and they were really bad."

In 1976 they bought a used lathe for $100 and Michelle got Frank Pain's book *Practical Woodturning*. She started turning and enjoyed it enough to continue. Another chance meeting nudged Michelle in a new direction when Mel Lindquist visited. "He'd stop by here and show us his little burl weed pots. I thought 'I can do that', so I started making the same kind of things and selling them to passers-by for $40 or $50."

LEFT TO RIGHT, TOP TO BOTTOM—
"Green Man Vase" (1989); maple burl; 10"x 14" x 4½".

"Green Man II Vase" (1990); maple; 10"x 10" x 3".

"Fibonacci Vase" (1991); maple; 9"x 9" x 3".

"Black & White Bowl" (2001); birch; H: 5" x D: 14".

Quite soon, Michelle got bored with the simplicity of this work and started carving the pieces after she turned them. Even with this added value, summer traffic wasn't enough to make a living, so they started doing craft shows, David with his furniture and Michelle with her carved turnings.







TOP TO BOTTOM—
"Macedonia Vase" (1986); beech burl; 14"x 14" x 4".

"Suspended Ring" (1996); maple; 13"x 14" x 3".

"Suspended Pilgrim" (2001); cherry burl; 12"x 13" x 3".

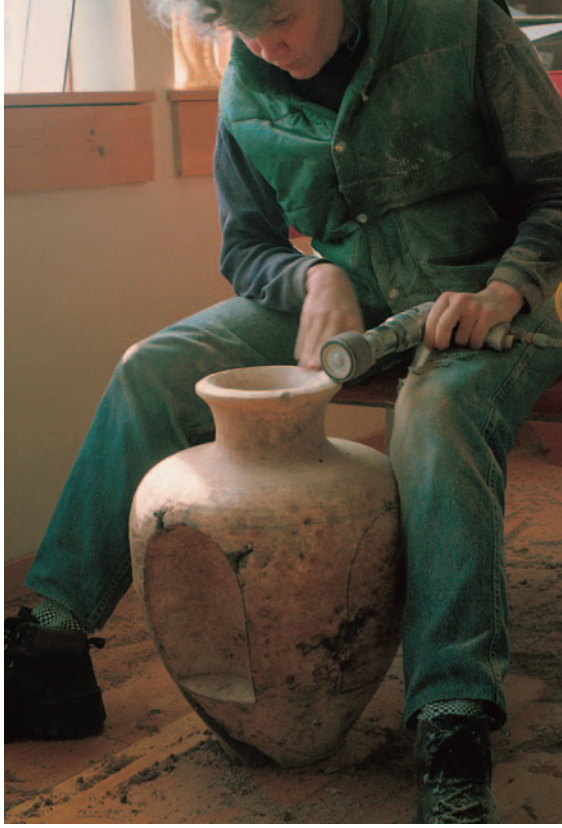
Michelle thinks it is a hard training ground: "Now, that's product testing. People will walk by and say the most cruel and thoughtless things, as well as the most wonderful things! As painful and exhausting as it was, it was a good way to toughen up. I'm not a particularly outgoing person, but I forced myself to do it. It was also the way we finally made contact with galleries or craft shops at that time."

David's and Michelle's work started to part ways more and more, but Michelle never forgets how important the mutual support has been: "My work was getting more complex and more expensive, while David's furniture was bulky and hard to carry, so he started to take custom orders from home, while I continued with galleries and shows. It's really because of David's support that I could start to make more expensive work, which sometimes meant I had to wait longer to sell."

When you review Michelle's work there are so many levels at which it can be appreciated. Her technical mastery alone is enough to delight, but for me the most interesting aspect is the sense of progression, of thoughtful development from one idea to the next. She clearly enjoys chewing over every concept, asking where it can go next and unfolding its potential in new pieces. Often this is done by taking surface decoration—which may originally have been carved on a vessel—lifting it from the vessel, reinterpreting it, and giving it a life of its own. This subsuming of the vessel by the decoration is shown in the progression from "Green Man Vase" to "Green Man Vase ll." The application of an idea in the first transforms into the embodiment of an idea in the second. In one, the idea is on the vase, while in the other the idea *is* the vase. The Green Men have smiling faces on one side and serious faces on the other. Michelle explains: "One side gets the joke; the other side doesn't. The two faces enclose a space where they can be of one mind."

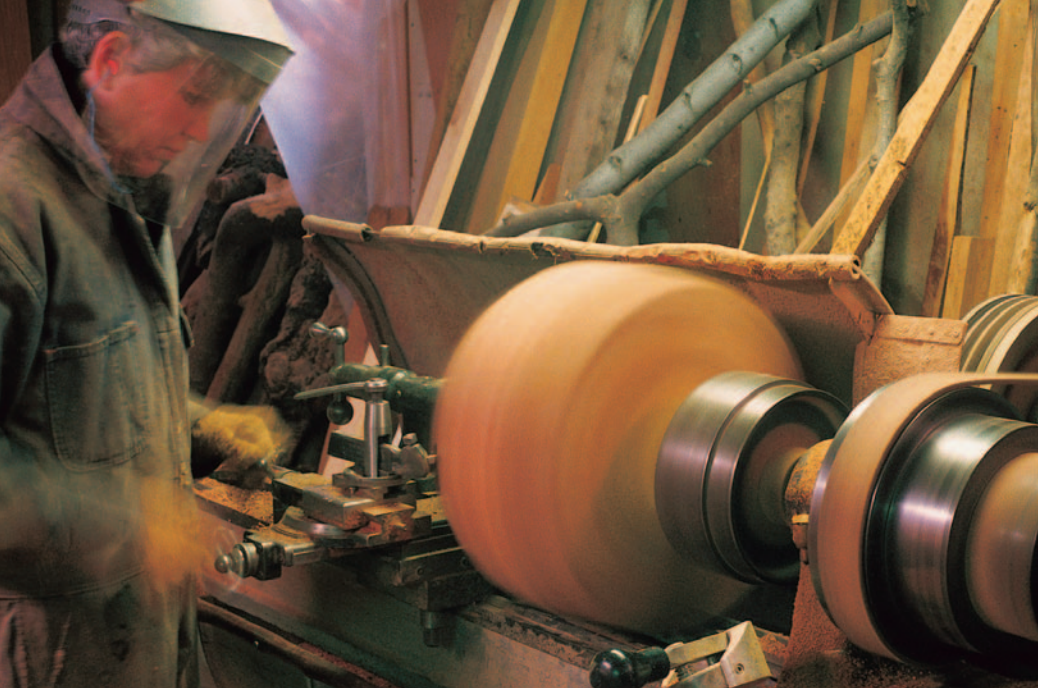
I like to think of different ideas swirling around in Michelle's head, colliding, bouncing off each other, then re-emerging as new interpretations. Sometimes they develop quite quickly, as with the Green Men, made only a year apart. "Fibonacci Vase" and "Black & White Bowl," however, were made ten years apart. The repeated and centrifugal pattern of the former becomes the exposed warp and weft of the latter. This piece says, "Here is what I do. Look at the idea more closely and you will see into my head." It is a glimpse into the mind of the young girl who sat with her mother and watched the needle work its way in and out of the fabric.

Progression is everything in Michelle's work. What a delight to watch how "Macedonia Vase," a handled urn made in 1986, re-emerged as "Suspended Ring" in 1996. It is a reflection of the many hours of contemplation that Michelle gave to the looping handles on the first vase. "What if…?", or "Why not…?" As if suspending the neck of the vase as a captive ring were not enough, by 2001 "Suspended Pilgrim" had taken the whole vessel and suspended it as a freely hanging, linked and yet separate piece. As a pilgrim can journey through life, this is a journey through the artist's mind. When seen like this, the evolution seems clear enough. But to imagine it in the mind's eye and then make it—that is a true leap of creativity.



Finishing the lip of a large vase with a pneumatic drill and drum sander. The niches were chainsawn.

This kind of work will mean different things to different viewers, but everyone must be struck by its sheer difficulty. Most of Michelle's sculptures are made from one block of wood, meaning that she has to deeply and carefully carve to separate the different elements, while never breaking the integrity of the whole. More than anything else, this almost perversely difficult technique shows her respect for the medium. For her, wood is not just a material to be subdued and bent to her will. Every piece has its own character and it must be respected. She believes that, "In some cases the material itself, such as multiple burls, strongly influences the final form. Freeing the form within the limits of the material is an ongoing challenge."



Holzapfel at the lathe she bought from her father—a machinist—who made it. She is using the compound tool holder and twirling both handles simultaneously; as she puts it, "like a 3-D Etch-a-Sketch."

Michelle's ability to push the limits is a combination of many factors. Her intense devotion to detail combined with many years of hard work have grown into prodigious skill. But that is merely the means to the end. It is her vision, and her determination to realize it, that makes this work sing. What Michelle is trying to say is: material, subject, technique are all questions to be posed. Not only *how* do we do it, but *what* are we doing and *why*?

By looking at how Michelle plays with one theme, we can catch a glimpse of her thought processes. In 1989 she produced "Linenfold Vase" and "Bound Vase," both playful ways to enhance the simple vase form. But then in 2000 she made "Ingénue Vase." This is a work of pure genius. An ingénue can be variously defined as an innocent or unsophisticated young woman, or an actress who plays the role of such a woman. Certainly, the chunky, buttoned-up knitwear would seem unsophisticated on a young woman, but on this vase it is a stroke of genius. Read into it yourself what you want to find: Woman's place in the world at large, or the smaller world each of us inhabits; Michelle's view of herself as a role-player meeting the expectations of an undemanding audience; a piece of sheer fun…I think it is all of these and more. What I like most of all is that, in a field where ideas are few and far between, this work stands out from all the rest for content.

This knitted theme is one Michelle often revisits. "Sweater Box"(1994), a superbly crafted statement about making complex sculpture from wood, poses the delightfully subversive question: If men are sometimes obsessed with their toolboxes, treating them as fetish items more than functional containers, why not make a fetish of a sweater box? Or why not make a wooden box of a fetish? Either way, it is fun and provocative. It is also very functional and, in sweet irony, Michelle uses it to store sweaters.

If you find yourself wondering what Michelle is trying to do, don't feel bad. She confesses that it is not always easy for her to understand her own work: "Sometimes when I am working, I'll suddenly think 'What's this stuff for? Is it just because someone needs something to put on their shelf?' But it's a kind of history. When I was a girl, I went to the museum and saw a beautiful big wooden Buddha. I'm indebted to whoever made that. That person didn't know where it would end up, but I saw it and it meant a lot to me. So when people ask me

LEFT TO RIGHT—
"Linenfold Vase" (1989); walnut; H: 15" x D: 7".

"Bound Vase" (1989); cherry burl; H: 14" x D: 12".

"Ingenue Vase" (2000); walnut, butternut; H: 10" x D: 6".



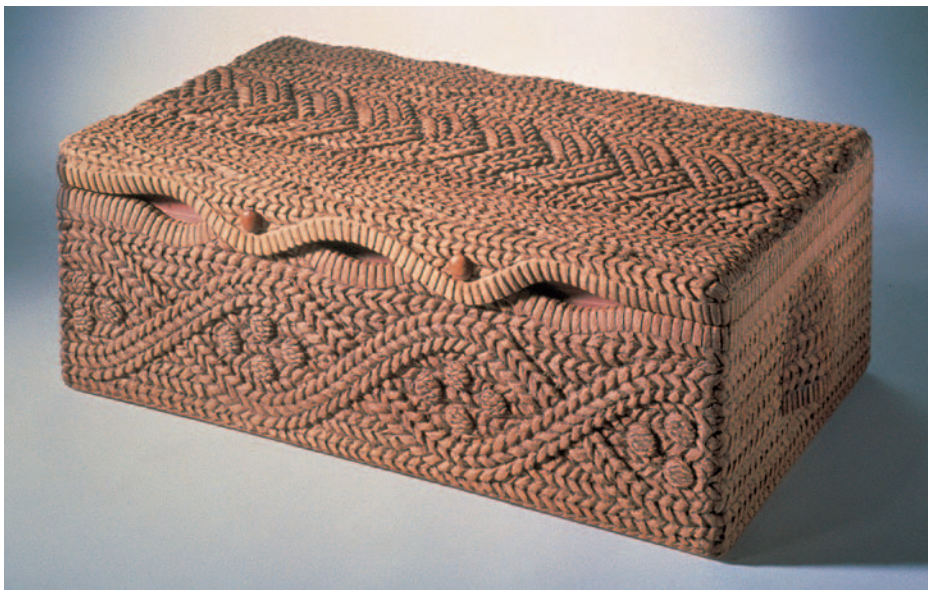




CLOCKWISE FROM TOP—
"Sweater Box" (1994); maple, cedar; 9" x 14" x 22".

"Cushioned Bowl I" (1998); sugar maple; 8" x 15"x 15".

"Menorah" (1995); birch; 20"x 10" x 18".







who I am thinking about when I make my work, I say 'I'm thinking about an eight-year-old girl.' I like to think that she will say, 'Wow, somebody made that back in 1994!'"

Beautiful words. Holzapfel is as much a wordsmith as a woodworker. "I love words. When I come across an interesting word, I go to the Oxford English Dictionary and look at the etymology. A word is like a museum, and its history unfolds. My pieces are like history, like poems, like narrative." "Menorah," made in 1995, is a striking example. Look up "menorah" in the dictionary and you will find it described as a "sacred candelabrum with seven branches." Why not make the branches out of branches? In a gesture of reverence, the hands caress and support the piece, uplifting the whole. This is handwork and this is worship.

In much of Michelle's work, the vessel is a metaphor for human aspirations. "Cushioned Bowl I" (1998) takes a simple bowl, which might normally have contained salad, and elevates it to regal status by placing it on a sumptuous cushion. Closer inspection reveals that the complex carved cushion and the simple bowl are made from one piece of wood. There are the usual two levels of delight: "What a great idea", and "What great carving!" "Olympia Vase" repeats this theme, but the contrast is even starker as the vase is bleached white and the bolster decorated with burnt texture. "Cordelia Vase" takes the metaphor even further. She may be supporting the vase, or it may be supporting her. Either way, Michelle is challenging us to think about facing or turning away; about relationships, in fact. "Ganymede Vase" poses this question even more poignantly. Look more closely. This is not just a hand. It is a hand enclosed in a fine kid glove, stitched beautifully and molded to every detail of the flesh beneath. Like Wendell Castle's famously wrapped grandfather clock, the hand is almost more present by being detected through the glove. If you want to share Michelle's fascination with words, look up "Ganymede" in a good dictionary and see what you make of this. Nothing in Michelle's work is by chance and we are left wondering why.

Michelle not only excels at this kind of exquisite detail, but she also carves free-form vessels which owe as much to the tree as to her art. "Snow Bowl," from 2000, is a delightful intertwined double vessel, while a year later "Paisley Bowls" has the two vessels knotted together, yet quite independent. To my mind these are an exploration of Michelle's relationships, not only with her work, but with those who are dear to her. We are all independ-

Hollowing a non-turned piece with an Arbortech® attached to an electric grinder. After sketching in the "foliage," she puts a dowel through a strategically-placed hole to help steady the workpiece.









COUNTERCLOCKWISE FROM UPPER LEFT—
"Olympia Vase" (2000); walnut, maple; 7" x 5" x 17".

"Cordelia Vase" (2000); cherry, maple, basswood; 11"x 12" x 7".

"Snow Bowl" (2000); maple; 10" x 12" x 26".

"Paisley Bowls" (2001); cherry; 14" x 10" x 4".

"Duet Vase" (2001); cherry burl; 12" x 15" x 6".

"Ganymede Vase" (2000); birch, basswood; 21"x 6" x 6".







ent, but we live in complex relationships, bound together in many ways. "Duet Vase" is another stunningly simple yet complex piece that conveys something of the intensity of human relations.

After a few delightful days as a guest of the Holzapfels, I returned on the train, alternately dozing from too much good wine and pondering what I had seen and heard at their house. What a marvellous artist and what an inspiration. To help those she does inspire, Michelle made the following observation at the 1993 World Turning Conference: "To me, everyone is self-taught. Opportunities to learn are as plentiful as the air we breathe; it's up to the learner to recognize and incorporate these experiences. It's debatable whether it's better to acquire formal training and then discard what you don't need, or whether it's sometimes preferable to grope along finding solutions where the well-trained might not look. Not-knowing has a special value: it's the ally, not the enemy, of knowing."

With work as beautiful and as complex as this, it is hard not to wonder how she comes up with the ideas. Luckily, Michelle was happy to explain: "When I listen to beautiful music, there are no words going through my mind. I'm just in a state of enjoyment. For me, the way a form sits in space has that kind of delight. I don't really worship the idea of originality, because I think its rather bogus. Unless you were brought up in a closet, I don't think you can say you are original. So these forms must pre-exist in my mind. All these things—watching my father repair the Jeep, watching my mother sew, walking in the woods—are grist for the mill. I have an innate ability to see these forms in my mind, to rotate them, to move through them. That's just what I can do and I don't have to try. It's unbidden, they just bubble up."

If anyone is tempted to imitate Michelle's ability to intellectualize, though, they might not get much encouragement from her. "Intellect is like technique," she says, "It's useful, but it's not everything, and it's not ultimately *the* thing. I do what I do for pure pleasure. Working on a piece, I sit down at 9:00 am and look down. The next thing I know it's noon. People ask me if I am patient. No, I'm not, but it's not a trial for me. It's like someone eating a big piece of chocolate cake for twenty minutes. They're not being patient, they're just enjoying every minute of it!" The only advice Michelle offers to would-be sculptors is very short: "The method is simple—it is the pure discipline of showing up every day."

Terry Martin is a contributing editor for Woodwork *magazine.*

Adding Textures

by Michelle Holzapfel

POLISHED WOOD IS BEAUTIFUL, but sometimes totally polished forms can lack interest. Mastering a palette of textures can enable you to give forms more visual and tactile appeal.

The key to convincing textures is first to carefully observe the real thing and to keep an open mind. For example, after trying many shop tools to create believable "pages" on carved books, I found that a serrated bread knife, drawn repeatedly across the straight edge of the page, created the most realistic deckled-edge texture. Check out the carving tool catalogs and use your imagination: eye punches are not just for making eyes.



STIPPLING

One of the most venerable and versatile strategies for adding contrast is stippling. I use a pneumatic pencil grinder that runs at 60,000 rpm and doesn't bog down when pressure is applied. Using a dull spherical burr—which heats up nicely at high speed—and consistent pressure, a series of small burned "dimples" can be formed. With judicious placement and \a modicum of patience, many kinds of textures can be achieved.

1. Care was taken to make neat, regular rows on this architecturally-inspired piece—a hit-or-miss texture would be inappropriate here.

2. In this more organic form, the dimples are placed in groups of four, each group forming a "cell." The taper of the form is accommodated by increasing or decreasing the cell sizes.

BURNING

Although the stippling technique includes burning (from the friction of the cutter), a good-quality woodburning tool can create a wealth of textures. I use one with a rheostatic control and a half-dozen differently-tipped handpieces.

3. The obvious use of the writing tip is to draw or write on the surface with little pressure.

4. The same technique, applied with a more formal design, yielded this "brocade" pattern. The stippling adds softness to the illusion of fabric.

5. A straight tip can be used to make closely-packed lines which resemble threads or hair. Much of the sharp undercutting of the tassels was achieved with a thin, pointed woodburning tip.

6. The snake's scales were formed with a pointed tip. Making convincing scales entails burning more deeply where they "overlap," and tapering the scales as the form tapers. A light stippling in concentric circles gives the outside of the bowl contrast to the highly polished interior.

CORDUROY OR FURROWS

A new, sharp spherical burr in the pencil grinder can also be employed to drag continuous lines, forming a furrowed texture.

7. Parallel lines create a stylized "leaf-vein" texture.

8. Furrows arranged in spirals imply a large-scale version of "fingerprints."

BLEACHING AND SCORCHING

9. The "base" for this walnut vase was made from a single piece of basswood. The book cover was finished with the woodburning tool, the "pages" were bleached, and the leaves were carved and oil-finished.

HAND WORK

10. Beading on the spine of the dragon was formed with "eye punch" tools which are available in carving tool catalogs. They range in size and are available in round or oval shapes. Packing different-sized beads close together on a surface makes a fabulously knobby reptilian texture.

11. Snakeskin texture is also available with a hand-carving gouge or v-tool. Just be patient.

FABRIC

12. This "quilted" top of a blanket chest was made more convincing by not polishing it too much. A drum sander with a coarse-grit mounted in a hand drill can be used to lightly apply "warp and weft" lines. First work the "threads" (parallel sanding marks) along the length of the "fabric," then work perpendicular "threads" lightly crossing to achieve a "linen" texture. The same strategy can be applied with a wire brush mounted in the drill.